

**Will McGowan**

9 Clarendon Place, Glasgow G20 7PZ

+44 7562 299 515 | mcgowanwill366@gmail.com

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Graduate Recruitment Team

Squarepoint Capital

London

Dear Sir or Madam,

I am applying for the Junior Discretionary Trader role in London. I am a final-year Economics student at the University of Strathclyde, graduating in summer 2027 with a predicted 2:1. Squarepoint's discretionary trading team, which runs strategies across equities, commodities, rates, FX and credit, offers the chance to learn judgement-led trading inside a firm built on systematic research.

My work keeps returning to one question: does an apparent edge survive a proper test? I tested CAPM on 694 anomaly portfolios across 54 countries and rejected zero alpha jointly in 48 of 53, with momentum the most persistent anomaly. My dissertation, supervised by Dr Luigi Gifuni, estimates petro-currencies' oil betas from OPEC announcement-day surprises, tests whether Norway's krone conversions, Russia's 2017–22 budget rule and Mexico's put hedge make them smaller, kinked or one-sided, and asks whether any beta that remains survives costs and a White reality check. As co-founder of the Strathclyde Agricapital Society, I also built a wheat calendar-spread strategy whose weekly backtest returned a Sharpe ratio of 0.76 before costs and 0.28 after, which taught me how quickly turnover erodes an edge.

Hedge funds appeal to me because the distance between an idea and its consequences is short: a research view becomes a position, and the position is marked every day. I take that accountability seriously. As Vice-President and then President of the Strathclyde Poker Society, I taught new members to use the Kelly criterion to work out how many buy-ins their win rate, variance and risk tolerance call for, with a buffer because their edge is only an estimate; a position sized on an uncertain alpha needs the same caution. As Treasurer of the Agricapital Society, which I helped grow to 126 members, I manage its budget and accounts.

Squarepoint stands out to me because it is expanding its discretionary business alongside its systematic core, so junior traders learn portfolio monitoring, maintenance and hedging from senior traders while working beside quantitative researchers. My own work moves between the two, systematic tests of factor premia and a rules-based wheat spread on one side and, in my dissertation, judgement about how government hedging rules shape the reaction to OPEC news on the other, and I would like to learn where a discretionary trader adds value that a model cannot.

I would welcome the opportunity to discuss my application. Thank you for your time and consideration.

Yours faithfully,

Will McGowan